prepare meticulously. He never preached to us, preferring to engage us with his anecdotes and leave us to draw our own conclusions.

Our days were filled with challenges such as rock climbing, walking across ice fields and sliding down waterfalls, but it is the second day that stands out in my memory.

With each of us kitted out in Gore-Tex from head to toe and wearing snow boots, we undertook a three-hour hike through deep snow to the summit of a 3 300-metre peak and continued with an undulating, tiring walk back to the base camp, where we found a truck fully loaded with mountain bikes.

'OK,' Mike announced, 'we're going to cycle over that mountain back to the hotel.'

We gazed up at the peak right in front of us and decided he was joking. Right? No, he was serious. Mike jumped on his bike and told us to follow. What ensued was the most physically demanding experience of my life. We cycled up a steep track for more than ten kilometres – on and on, up and up, pushing ourselves and each other further than we would have imagined possible, getting to a point where we thought we could go no further, and yet carrying on.

When we reached the summit, we expected an easy free-wheel descent down the other side, but we were wrong again. The path down to the village was so steep that several of us decided it would be wiser to carry our bikes and continue the journey on foot. Others opted to cycle, and I saw Alviro Petersen tumble forward over his handlebars and fall so hard that I doubted he would be able to continue. He did.

We were being tested together, and we were going to get the job done together. By the time I arrived back at our hotel, I had rarely felt so exhausted, and rarely felt so exhilarated. As a squad of professional cricketers, we had been taken to places we had never been before, and the experience yielded instant results. Properly prepared and motivated, we were ready to overcome.